

Photographs by **RAJWANT RAWAT**

There is a digital test, and you have to study a thick book. Only after passing the examination do you get a licence.

Q. Why can't India enforce such strict rules for licences?
In India, it's different because road transport is on the concurrent list and there is a problem with the law and the system. There are a lot of gaps where both we and the states need to comply with regulations. We have to make the system more transparent, time-bound and corruption-free. We have changed the laws and increased the fines, but even then people are not learning. We are now opening many driver training schools and taking a lot of measures. But it is still a problem for me that people in this country do not understand the impact of road rule violations and the huge loss of life it causes. It's a big challenge to create awareness, respect for the law and, most importantly, to ensure that every citizen obeys the rules of the road. Without changing human behaviour, we cannot change the situation.

Q. Many highways seem badly engineered, which is one of the cause of road accidents...
Yes, ensuring correct and precise road engineering is very important. We have identified blackspots and created a scheme to spend ₹40,000 crore on improving these blackspots. So far, there are more than 10,000 blackspots, out of which 6,500 have already been improved. But when we are building new roads, the people who are making the Detailed Project Reports (DPR) continue to make mistakes, and that is one of the reasons we need to improve road engineering. We are taking preventive measures to address this, and if there is a mistake, we will take action against the companies responsible for the DPR. My responsibility is to ensure that DPRs for road projects are 100 per cent perfect. There should be no accidents caused by faulty road engineering.

"It is so easy to get a licence here. In the US, there is a digital written test for which you have to study a thick book. Only if you pass do you get a licence"

Q. What about stricter enforcement of road rules?
Enforcement of law is very impor-